Westbrook School Committee

~ Regular Meeting ~

Date: Wednesday, May 13, 2026
Time: 7:00 PM
Location: Westbrook High School (Room 114), 117 Stroudwater St. (Hybrid via Zoom)
Video: https://vimeo.com/1192079480
Packet: No agenda was published for this meeting (checked westbrookschools.org/page/westbrook-school-committee, 2026-10-24).

Timestamps below are clickable [0:00]-style links — they jump straight to that moment in the video.

This summary highlights the meeting's key discussions and decisions, with direct quotes and timestamps for verification — it is not a substitute for watching the full meeting. *Six of seven regular members were present (Brooke Reed not confirmed present at roll call; all votes this meeting tallied 6); both student representatives attended. Summarization necessarily condenses and selects; for complete context, nuance, and anything not covered, watch the full video at the link above. (Produced by: WestbrookCurrents.com)*

Reports

Superintendent's Report [3:29]

Discussion Summary

Seven retirements announced, to be honored at the June meeting: kindergarten teacher Sandy Beasley, bus driver Eric Jensen, Westbrook Middle School literacy intervention teacher Anne LaRue, van driver Margaret McNair, Westbrook High School college/career counselor Nicole Sturgis, executive assistant Sharon Bernier (returning part-time), and bus driver Jody Peterson.

High School band director Kyle Smith was named Maine's 2026 High School Music Educator of the Year.

Other notes: Staff Appreciation Week; strong applicant pools for open positions; 76 students inducted into the National Technical Honor Society at the Westbrook Regional Vocational Center (WRVC); the National Art Honor Society induction and the high school art show; and the Sacarappa Masons' annual Books for Bikes program.

Key Decisions

Action Items

None.

Chair's Report [9:18]

Discussion Summary

The FY27 school budget received a “resounding” City Council vote of approval and is now out for the school budget referendum vote. Early voting is open at City Hall; the referendum itself is June 9 at the Westbrook Community Center.

Key Decisions

Action Items

None.

Student Representative Report — Tina Duin & Jamila Mohamed Ahmed [10:51]

Discussion Summary

The second annual Westbrook High School talent show (seniors Orgy and Elspeth took first place); AP testing complete.

WRVC's awards ceremony is May 21; WRVC student of the year Madison Willette received a $1,500 scholarship from the Maine Blue Collar Scholarship Foundation.

A long list of elementary/middle-school spring events: drama productions, the fourth-grade “All Cities B” academic competition, cultural-tradition and family nights, and grade-transition activities.

Key Decisions

Action Items

None.

Finance Committee Report — Noreen Poitras [15:59]

Discussion Summary

Monthly financials generally on track, aside from a temporary deficit from moving the finance director's position into the superintendent's budget line.

A reallocation of unused lacrosse funds toward a partnership with Back Bay/Portland lacrosse; a roughly 1% overall increase expected in federal Title funding, not confirmed until June.

Pre-K enrollment at 52 registered, 30 in process, with a possible future request for an additional full-time pre-K classroom (about $120,000) still unofficial pending enrollment numbers. In Q&A, Superintendent Lancia said funding could come from a position vacated by retirement/resignation or from federal funds, that space exists at Canal School for one more classroom if needed, and that a new hire, if required, would need committee authorization in June.

Key Decisions

Action Items

None.

Educational Programs Report — Katy Rice [23:02]

Discussion Summary

Transition supports for 4th-to-5th and 8th-to-9th grade (step-up days, parent nights, a new movement break built into the 5th-grade schedule); continuing work on gifted/accelerated programming to carry into the fall.

A new Humanities diploma endorsement, joining the existing STEM and Visual/Performing Arts endorsements, available starting with the Class of 2027.

A Class of 2026 graduation rate of 86% (94% including alternative pathways), above the national average.

Pre-K hiring and space planning continuing, with a “Pre-K for Me” summer training and a new pre-K advisory council; the 2026–27 professional development theme, “I Matter Here,” is built around the SIOP instructional framework's eight qualities of outstanding instruction, to be introduced over a two-year arc.

Key Decisions

Action Items

None.

Policy Committee Report — Erin Cavallaro [31:38]

Discussion Summary

Three policies reviewed and brought to the board this same evening: JICJ (student device use), EEA (student transportation), and IKB (homework) — see New Business below. Next meeting May 27 will take up BEDH (public participation, prompted by a recent Superior Court injunction) and a personnel-complaints policy.

Key Decisions

Action Items

None.

New Business

12.1–12.3 — Staff Advancement to the Next Contract Step (Taken in the Aggregate) [34:28]

Discussion Summary

First-year probationary teachers to second-year; second-year probationary teachers to continuing contract; first-year probationary administrators to second-year.

Key Decisions

✓ Approved 6–0, first and final, moved by Katy Rice, seconded by Noreen Poitras.

Action Items

None.

12.4 — Policy JICJ — Student Use of Devices (Bell-to-Bell Cell Phone Ban), First Approval [35:45]

Discussion Summary

Implements a state mandate, effective August 1, 2026, requiring all Maine districts to ban personal electronic devices (phones, smartwatches, AirPods) bell-to-bell.

Erin Cavallaro explained the policy grew out of an ad hoc committee she co-chaired with high school co-principal Patrick Colgan since last fall, informed by a December survey of high school students and staff and input from parent/City Councilor Brian McCambridge. The change is most significant at the high school, which currently allows phone use in hallways, study halls, and the cafeteria.

Key Decisions

✗ 5 in favor, 1 opposed (Poitras).

Action Items

None.

> *“I just want to put it out there. I am not in favor of this at all. I worry about the safety of the students in the case of an emergency, that you cannot unlock their phones if a parent is trying to … get hold of the parents to calm them down. I know it's a mandate from the state, but I still do not approve it.”*
>
> **— Noreen Poitras [40:34]**

12.5 — Policy EEA — Student Transportation, First Approval [41:23]

Discussion Summary

Adds pre-K to the policy's predefined-stop provisions, following the Transportation ad hoc committee's review.

Key Decisions

✓ Approved 6–0, moved by Erin Cavallaro, seconded by Katy Rice.

Action Items

None.

12.6 — Policy IKB — Homework, First Approval [41:47]

Discussion Summary

Revised “through the lens of equity,” so expectations account for unequal resources/support at home.

Key Decisions

✓ Approved 6–0, moved by Erin Cavallaro, seconded by Dr. Flynn Ross.

Action Items

None.

12.8 — MLTI Purchase, 2026–2027, First Approval [42:14]

Discussion Summary

Taken out of order — see procedural note below.

Key Decisions

✓ Approved 6–0, moved by Erin Cavallaro, seconded by Noreen Poitras.

Action Items

None.

12.7 — Delete Policy IKB-R — Homework Administrative Procedure [42:44]

Discussion Summary

Caught by a point of order from Poitras after the board skipped past it; Cavallaro explained it is duplicative of the just-revised IKB homework policy.

Procedural note: Chair Mancuso inadvertently skipped from 12.6 to 12.8, voted on 12.8, then returned to 12.7 after Poitras flagged the gap — both items' votes stand as cast (6–0 each); no revote was needed.

Key Decisions

✓ Approved 6–0, first and final, moved by Katy Rice, seconded by Erin Cavallaro.

Action Items

None.

12.9 — Reallocate Funds to Purchase Yonder (Faraday) Pouches for Westbrook High School, First Approval [44:05]

Discussion Summary

Funding comes from the FY27 budget's contingency line, timed for next fiscal year rather than the current “leaner than lean” FY26 budget.

Erin Cavallaro described the pouches — magnetic-lock pouches issued to every student, with wall-mounted and portable unlocking stations, the portable ones intended specifically for emergencies, directly addressing Poitras's safety concern from item 12.4. The final cost came in roughly half of the committee's original estimate.

Key Decisions

✗ 5 in favor, 1 opposed (Poitras).

Action Items

None.

12.10 — Overnight Field Trip: WRVC Automotive Students to the SEMA Educational Convention, Las Vegas, NV, November 3–6, 2026 [50:21]

Discussion Summary

Moved by Katy Rice, seconded by Erin Cavallaro.

Key Decisions

✓ Approved 6–0, first and final.

Action Items

None.

12.11 — Overnight Field Trip: WRVC Career-Readiness Tour, London, During April Break 2028 [51:23]

Discussion Summary

In response to a question from Dr. Flynn Ross, Superintendent Lancia confirmed no district/taxpayer funds are involved — the trip would be funded entirely through fundraising, student payments, and sponsorships, contingent on sufficient student interest.

Key Decisions

✓ Approved 6–0, first and final, moved by Katy Rice, seconded by Noreen Poitras.

Action Items

None.

Announcements

Governor's Visit & Student Recognition [55:20]

Discussion Summary

Erin Cavallaro announced that Governor Janet Mills will visit Westbrook High School on May 27 at 10:00 AM for a ceremonial bill signing of the statewide bell-to-bell cell phone ban.

Katy Rice recognized both student representatives for multiple awards at the recent Academic Recognition Night.

Key Decisions

Action Items

None.

Important Dates

Upcoming Meetings & Events [52:42]

Discussion Summary

May 20, 5:00 PM: Facilities Committee (Sacarappa). May 27, 5:00 PM: Policy Committee. June 2: Class Night (Performing Arts Center). June 5–6: Westbrook Together Days. June 6, 6:00 PM: Class of 2026 graduation (Merrill Auditorium). June 9: school budget referendum vote (Westbrook Community Center, all day). June 10, 7:00 PM: regular School Committee meeting. June 17: last day of school (half day).

Key Decisions

Action Items

None.

Executive Session

12.12 — Enter Executive Session — Personnel Matter & Support Staff Contract Negotiations [54:21]

Discussion Summary

Pursuant to 1 M.R.S.A. §405(6)(A) (a personnel matter) and §405(6)(D) (support staff contract negotiations).

Per the chair's announced change to the agenda order at the start of the meeting, the committee adjourned directly from executive session with no further public action.

Key Decisions

✓ Approved 6–0, moved by Noreen Poitras, seconded by Katy Rice.

Action Items

None.

How this was made

This summary was produced from the meeting video (linked above, hosted on the City's Vimeo showcase). The audio was downloaded with Downie 4 and transcribed with speaker diarization using MacWhisper. Claude (Anthropic's AI) cross-checked names against the official School Committee roster, attributed speakers from context (introductions, roll-call order, direct address by the Chair) rather than the raw diarization labels alone, and drafted this summary and the quoted excerpts. Quotes are lightly cleaned of filler words/false starts but not reworded. No agenda or back-up packet was published for this meeting (checked westbrookschools.org, 2026-10-24); this summary is drawn from the video/transcript alone. Review tier: Not reviewed.

Produced by Westbrook Currents — westbrookcurrents.com